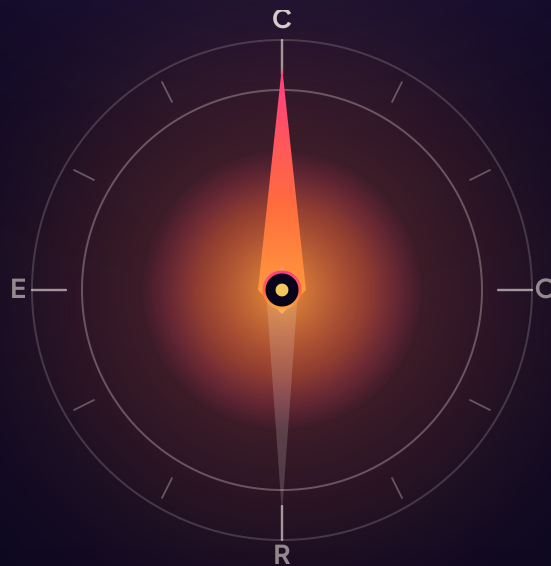


● STRATEGY BRIEF



Competitive *compass.*

Career discovery, education pathways, and
job-matching competitors — where Tareeq
stands and where the white space lies.

Executive *read.*

The career discovery space splits into four lanes: **psychometric assessments** (CareerExplorer, YouScience), **school pathway platforms** (Unifrog), **AI strengths and job-matching** (Mentra, PathwayU), and **end-to-end pathway apps** (Yenza, ISMOJO). Each of them solves one stage well. None of them solves the full arc — assessment, local pathway, weekly action, family context — for a young Muslim-majority audience whose decisions are shaped as much by elders and community as by the individual.

Tareeq's position is not *another career test*. It is a guided pathway app that turns CORE assessment results into local opportunities, mentor and counselor support, and weekly action steps a 16-year-old can actually take this week. The product surface we already ship — the editorial onboarding, the compass-as-progress mechanic, the calm night surface, Kai as a non-coercive guide — is the foundation. The competitive opportunity is to extend that arc past the assessment into the parts of the journey that don't yet exist in any single competitor's product.

Closest competitor by lane

- **End-to-end pathway model** · Yenza Careers — the most structurally similar to where Tareeq is heading. Assessment → career match → action plan, served on the African continent. Their model validates the thesis; Tareeq's edge is MENA cultural fluency, Arabic-first voice, and family-aware framing.
- **Regional / MENA-adjacent signal** · ISMOJO — operates in the same cultural orbit, builds school partnerships, and proves there's demand. Their gap: thin on assessment depth and on the editorial / mentorship layer.
- **Schools go-to-market** · Unifrog and YouScience — institutional moats, deep counselor tooling. If Tareeq sells into schools, these set the bar. The opening: the consumer-grade experience neither of them delivers to the student themselves.
- **Free consumer funnel** · CareerExplorer — strongest SEO and content-led acquisition. They convert curiosity into a 16-minute assessment and a paid upgrade. Tareeq can match their funnel and out-deliver their post-assessment experience.
- **Strengths-aware matching inspiration** · Mentra — built for neurodivergent talent. Useful template for how Tareeq frames difference as fit rather than deficit.

The wedge

No competitor is solving for the *"after"*. Every product in this set hands the user back a report, a cluster, or a match — and then ends. Tareeq's defensible product is what happens in the seven days after the assessment: a local opportunity surfaced, a mentor or counselor connection offered, a small action proposed and completed, and a parent-friendly summary the family can read together. That arc is the moat.

Competitor *snapshot matrix*.

Seven players, viewed across the four axes that matter for Tareeq: what lane they own, who they serve, what they actually deliver, and how closely they overlap with our wedge.

BRAND	PRIMARY LANE	AUDIENCE	CORE DELIVERABLE	REGIONAL FIT (MENA)	TAREEQ OVERLAP
Yenza Careers	End-to-end pathway	16–25, African continent	Assessment + career match + structured action plan + content library	ADJACENT	DIRECT
ISMOJO	Regional pathway / schools	Students & schools, MENA-adjacent	Career exploration + school partnerships + light assessment	HIGH	DIRECT
Unifrog	School pathway platform	Schools, counselors, students 14–18	University & apprenticeship search + counselor tooling	LIMITED	PARTIAL
YouScience	Aptitude assessment / schools	US schools, students 13–22	Brain-game aptitude tests + career & major matches	LOW	PARTIAL
PathwayU	Purpose-fit assessment	US college students & HE institutions	Purpose, interests, workplace fit assessment + major fit	LOW	PARTIAL
CareerExplorer	Consumer assessment + content	Adults & teens, global English	Long-form psychometric assessment + 1,000+ career library + premium	LOW	FUNNEL
Mentra	Neurodivergent job matching	Neurodivergent professionals + employers	Strengths-aware profile + employer matching marketplace	LOW	INSPIRATION

Where overlap is direct

Yenza Careers and ISMOJO are the only two competitors solving the same shape of problem Tareeq is shipping. Both win on specific dimensions Tareeq can exceed: **Yenza on structured action arcs, ISMOJO on regional school distribution.**

Where overlap is structural, not direct

Unifrog, YouScience, PathwayU and CareerExplorer overlap in tooling and methodology but serve a different audience and distribution model. They're benchmarks, not blockers.

Individual *competitor profiles*.

Yenza Careers

yenzacareers.com

● CLOSEST ANALOGUE · END-TO-END PATHWAY

AUDIENCE

Youth and young professionals across the African continent (16–25).

STRENGTHS

Coherent product narrative, strong African distribution, clear "after the test" arc, content depth.

WHAT THEY SELL

A guided arc: assessment → career match → structured action plan → editorial content library. Direct-to-student.

GAPS TAREEQ CAN EXPLOIT

Not built for MENA cultural context, not Arabic-first, no family/elder framing, no mentor pairing.

Tareeq takeaway: Yenza proves the end-to-end pathway thesis. Win by being the version built for Arabic-speaking and Muslim-majority youth, with family-aware framing and a mentor layer Yenza doesn't yet ship.

ISMOJO

ismojo.com

● CLOSEST REGIONAL SIGNAL · MENA-ADJACENT

AUDIENCE

Students and schools, with regional / MENA-adjacent positioning.

STRENGTHS

Regional credibility, school relationships, validated demand in the territories Tareeq targets.

WHAT THEY SELL

Career exploration tooling, school partnerships, light assessment functionality. B2B-leaning go-to-market.

GAPS TAREEQ CAN EXPLOIT

Thin on assessment depth, no editorial / mentorship layer, limited consumer-grade product polish.

Tareeq takeaway: ISMOJO confirms the regional demand and the school channel works. Tareeq's edge is product quality: the assessment depth, the editorial onboarding, and the Kai mentor voice are all surfaces ISMOJO doesn't compete on.

Individual *competitor profiles*.

Unifrog

unifrog.org

● SCHOOL PATHWAY PLATFORM

AUDIENCE

Schools, counselors, students 14–18. Heavy institutional play.

STRENGTHS

Deep counselor tooling, comprehensive destination database, strong school distribution outside the US.

WHAT THEY SELL

A "destinations" platform — universities, apprenticeships, jobs, gap years — plus counselor dashboards and tools.

GAPS TAREEQ CAN EXPLOIT

Student-facing experience is institutional, not consumer-grade. No emotional voice, no editorial onboarding, no mentor layer.

Tareeq takeaway: If selling into schools, Unifrog sets the depth bar for destination data. Out-compete by being the product the student actually wants to open — not the tool the counselor assigns.

YouScience

youscience.com

● APTITUDE ASSESSMENT / SCHOOLS

AUDIENCE

US schools (mostly), students 13–22.

STRENGTHS

Differentiated assessment methodology, US school distribution, clean aptitude-to-career storyline.

WHAT THEY SELL

Brain-game style aptitude assessments that produce career and major matches, sold institutionally to schools.

GAPS TAREEQ CAN EXPLOIT

US-centric, no regional fit, expensive institutional model, limited weekly-action layer post-assessment.

Tareeq takeaway: YouScience is the strongest schools-channel benchmark for assessment quality. Tareeq's 12-minute CORE assessment can match it on rigor while feeling like a product students choose to take, not one they're handed.

Individual *competitor profiles*.

PathwayU

pathwayu.com

● PURPOSE-FIT ASSESSMENT

AUDIENCE

US college students and higher-ed institutions.

STRENGTHS

The "purpose" framing resonates emotionally. Strong institution partnerships, polished outputs.

WHAT THEY SELL

Purpose-led assessment (purpose, interests, workplace style) that matches to majors, careers, and degrees.

GAPS TAREEQ CAN EXPLOIT

Built for college, not pre-college decisions. US workplace model bakes into matches. No local-opportunity layer.

Tareeq takeaway: Borrow the emotional weight of "purpose" framing. Apply it earlier in the journey (16–18, not 18–22), with MENA workplace realities and family context baked in.

CareerExplorer

careerexplorer.com

● FREE CONSUMER ASSESSMENT + CONTENT FUNNEL

AUDIENCE

Adults and teens, global English, primarily SEO-acquired.

STRENGTHS

SEO machine, career library breadth, conversion funnel from free assessment to paid features.

WHAT THEY SELL

A long-form psychometric assessment + 1,000+ career profiles + premium content. Massive SEO content moat.

GAPS TAREEQ CAN EXPLOIT

No regional fit. No local opportunity layer. Content is generic; experience is "fill out this form".

Tareeq takeaway: Model the top-of-funnel. Free, well-structured 12-minute assessment with SEO-ready career cluster pages. Then differentiate downstream with the "after" layer they don't ship.

Individual *competitor profiles*.

Mentra

mentra.com

● STRENGTHS-AWARE, INCLUSIVE JOB MATCHING

AUDIENCE

Neurodivergent professionals and the employers who hire them. Adjacent, not direct competition.

STRENGTHS

Story-driven onboarding, strengths-as-superpower framing, clear emotional voice.

WHAT THEY SELL

A strengths-first profile and an employer-side marketplace, built around inclusive matching.

GAPS TAREEQ CAN EXPLOIT

Different audience entirely — but the framing language is borrowable for Tareeq's CORE results page.

Tareeq takeaway: Inspiration, not competition. The way Mentra frames difference as fit-not-deficit is the model for how Tareeq should narrate a CORE persona to a 16-year-old who has only ever been told they're "good at school" or "not".

Reading the field as a whole

Across the seven, the same shape repeats: an assessment, a result, a library, a paywall. The product surfaces all collapse into variations of the same noun — a *test*. Tareeq is the only one in this set that has the chance to be a *path*: something the user walks, not something the user takes.

What Tareeq should *do differently*.

The competitive set above hands the user a result and ends. Tareeq's product begins where they end. Six strategic differentiators define the wedge.

01 · Arabic-first, MENA-fluent

Bilingual EN/AR throughout, including TTS narration with Kai's voice in both. No competitor in this set ships Arabic-first. This alone defines a 50M+ youth audience moat.

02 · Family-aware framing

A parent-friendly summary of the user's CORE compass — written to be read aloud at the dinner table. The decision is the family's, not just the individual's.

03 · Local opportunity layer

Real internships, programs, university pathways, and scholarships in the user's city or country, surfaced contextually from their CORE result. Beats generic global career library.

04 · Mentor & counselor pairing

Not a chatbot — a human mentor warm-introduced based on cluster match. Counselor mode for schools mirrors the same flow.

05 · Weekly action steps

One actionable next step delivered each week post-assessment — an exploratory chat, a free course, a portfolio prompt. Turns a test into a habit.

06 · Compass, not GPS

Tareeq points the direction. The user chooses the destination. This editorial voice — already established on /intro and /contract — is the brand wedge no competitor matches.

Suggested *MVP modules*.

Six modules form a complete product surface. The first two are already shipping in production at **tareeq-gray.vercel.app**. The remaining four are the post-assessment arc — Tareeq's defensible territory and the part no competitor in this set delivers.

Shipping today

A · CORE assessment (12 min)

FOUNDATION · LIVE

54-question assessment across four pillars (Curiosities, Operations, Rewards, Ecosystems). Editorial onboarding with Kai, ritualistic Contract of Honesty, animated compass, milestone "Did you know" beats.

B · Compass result + persona

FOUNDATION · NEXT SPRINT

A named persona derived from the CORE pillars, framed as fit not score. Borrows Mentra's strengths-as-superpower framing for the local cultural context.

The defensible "after"

C · Local pathway library

WEDGE · NONE OF THE 7 SHIP THIS

Programs, internships, scholarships, and university tracks within the user's country, filtered by CORE cluster. Seed with 5 anchor countries (KSA, UAE, Egypt, Jordan, Morocco).

D · Mentor & counselor pairing

WEDGE · PARTIAL OVERLAP WITH YENZA

A vetted human mentor matched on cluster + language + region. Counselor mode for schools mirrors the same flow for institutional buyers.

E · Weekly next step

WEDGE · NO COMPETITOR DELIVERS CADENCE

One actionable next step per week post-assessment, tailored to cluster: a chat prompt, a free course, a portfolio task, a profile to message. Turns a one-time test into a 12-week habit.

F · Family / elder summary

WEDGE · ENTIRELY UNADDRESSED

A one-page printable or share-ready summary of the user's CORE compass and pathway — written for parents and elders, in their register. Removes the family conversation as a friction point.

Prioritization for *Tareeq*.

Sequenced by defensibility × effort. The first quadrant is what ships before fundraise; the rest define the 6–12 month roadmap.

NOW — HIGH IMPACT, LOW EFFORT

- Ship the **compass result + persona** page (B).
- Seed the **local pathway library** in 2 anchor countries (C, MVP slice).
- Stand up the **family-summary** printable (F).
- Bilingual EN/AR Kai voiceover on /intro and /q/* (locks the moat).

NEXT — HIGH IMPACT, HIGHER EFFORT

- **Mentor pairing v1** (D) — manual matching, 50 mentors.
- **Weekly next step** push (E) — 12-week cluster-specific arc.
- Extend pathway library (C) to 5 anchor countries.

LATER — HIGH IMPACT, DEFER FOR SCALE

- Counselor / schools mode (B2B variant of D + admin tooling).
- Mentor marketplace (productize matching, vetting, payouts).
- Localization beyond Arabic (Bahasa, Urdu).

NOT YET — KILL OR POSTPONE

- Generic global career library (CareerExplorer territory).
- University destination database depth (Unifrog territory).
- Adult re-skilling lane (different ICP, different product).

The wedge in one sentence

The first Tareeq user to finish the assessment, get matched to a mentor in their city, receive a family-readable summary, and complete week one's action step — that's the moment no competitor in this set can replicate.

Source *notes*.

Competitor analysis drawn from each company's public website and publicly available product surface as of 2026. Where claims are made about pricing, distribution, or feature depth, they reflect what the company itself publishes.

Yenza Careers	https://www.yenzacareers.com/en
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ISMOJO	https://ismojo.com/
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Unifrog	https://www.unifrog.org/
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YouScience	https://www.youscience.com/
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PathwayU	https://pathwayu.com/
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CareerExplorer	https://www.careerexplorer.com/
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Mentra	https://www.mentra.com
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Tareeq reference surface

Live product: **tareeq-gray.vercel.app**. Design tokens and the redesigned v2 system referenced throughout this document live in the working tree at **app/globals.css** and **tailwind.config.ts**. The compass mechanic, the editorial onboarding (/intro, /contract), and the assessment flow (/q/*) are all in production.

Methodology note

This document is a strategic brief, not a third-party audit. Numerical claims about competitor scale, pricing, or audience size have been intentionally avoided where they cannot be sourced from the company's own materials. The competitive read is qualitative and product-shape focused — designed to inform Tareeq's roadmap, not to benchmark KPIs.